

the "no leather, no shatoosh" stance their style slogan, but today, creative minds are innovating to create ecologically-sensitive couture. So while director general of the Fashion Design Council of India (FDCI) Rathni Vinay Jha, who belongs to the cult of crisp cotton saris and crisper comments, has taken the initiative and announced a tie-up with Conserve India, an NGO that creates fashion out of handmade recycled plastic, Mumbai-based designer Anita Dongre returns to her roots with an ecologically sensitive spring-summer line Grassroots. According to her, the collection is a "fashion movement" that encourages the use of textiles made with the help of eco-friendly techniques. "I decided to work with Natural Dyes, an NGO that works with the tribes of Sawantwadi because they create colour-fast and UV protective vegetable dyes that are environment friendly," explains Dongre, who says the project makes commercial sense and also satisfies her creatively. "I am working on making a strong fabric woven organically and coloured in vegetable dyes," she adds.

And even as the Grassroots philosophy prepares to take root through umpteen outlets, Malini Ramani has taken a step further from her resort-wear line and moved towards spa-wear with the launch of her label Mystic M by mid-September. "Health has become big internationally as well as personally. Yoga, detox and organic have become the buzzwords. These have also reflected in my life and changed my fashion outlook," she says. Her spring-summer line Tree of Life combines organic fabrics with shell embroidery, jute, bamboo and wooden beads.

Designer Payal Jain, who loves working with organic fabrics and crafts, aims to weed out any exploitation of labourers by working directly with them. "I love to use natural fabrics like cotton, linen and handloom. And even though Chinese fabric is cheaper, I prefer to use Indian handlooms with

MALINI RAMANI

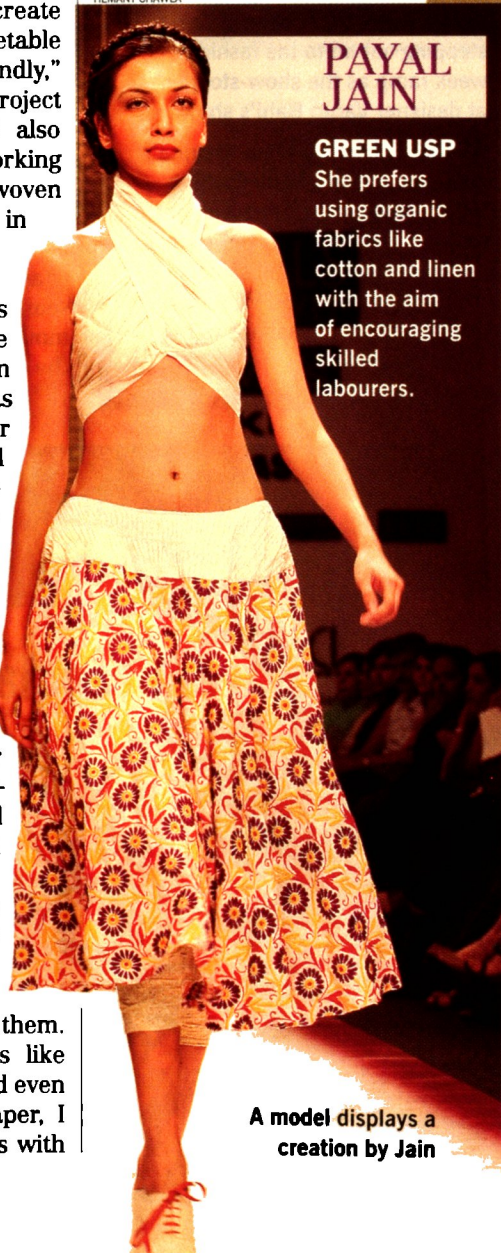
GREEN USP
Her spring-summer line Tree of Life combines organic fabric with jute and wooden beads. She will move towards spa-wear with the launch of her label Mystic M in mid-September.



HEMANT CHAWLA

PAYAL JAIN

GREEN USP
She prefers using organic fabrics like cotton and linen with the aim of encouraging skilled labourers.



A model displays a creation by Jain

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So while designers like Jain, Rajesh Pratap Singh, Abhishek & Nandita of Fightercock and Aparna and Norden Wangdi, among others, reinforce the refreshment of cotton at WIFW, efforts of Conserve India only add to accessorising this environment friendly trend.

From monitoring energy efficiency, waste management and household waste, Anita Ahuja hit upon the ingenious idea of processing plastic into thicker fabric that can be made into fashionable bags, belts and other fashion accessories. While her band of local helpers, who speak different languages now, differentiate colours through a common Bollywood lingo (Black is for Shah Rukh Khan, pink for Kareena), Ahuja is happy about her effort grabbing attention at the fashion week.

Meanwhile, Jha is only too happy to encourage her brood. "It's nice to see designers aligning themselves with a worthy cause. In fact, we'd like to encourage them to work not only for the environment but also on issues like the girl child and empowerment of women. I want to change the perception of fashion week being a tamasha," says Jha.

But if the week-long tamasha does help in popularising recycled plastic and organic weaves, here is an effort that will not go waste, literally. ■